



▲ Dance with the Devil

Witches supposedly danced with the Devil at black sabbaths in the woods, as depicted here in the 17th-century *Compendium of Witchery* by Francesco Maria Gouache.

In 1390, the French Parlement of Paris passed an act against witchcraft and rapidly found four subjects—first Marion du Droiturière and Margot de la Barre, then Macette de Ruilly and Jehenne de Brigue—guilty. All four women were accused of using witchcraft and burned at the stake. All four, too, like Irish maidservant Petronilla de Meath, the first woman to be burned to death for witchcraft in the British Isles (see p.115), were convicted on the strength of confessions extracted under torture. The use of torture against women and men accused of witchcraft soon became the norm.

These first victims of the drive against witchcraft were all accused of using their magical powers to manipulate men. Their convictions were part of an

► Trial by fire

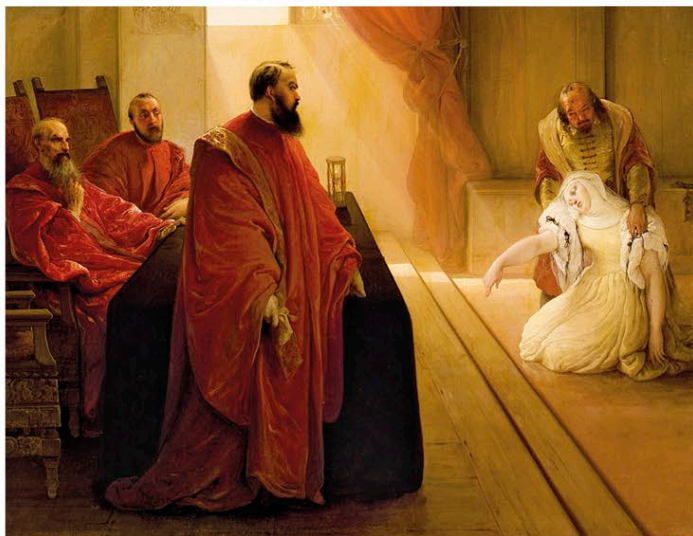
With his efforts to convert heretics, St. Dominic inspired Dominican monks to become the most zealous witch-hunters of the medieval era. Here, St. Dominic's true books miraculously survive a fire, while heretical books are consumed.

increasingly misogynistic view of women as either chaste and saintly paragons in courtly romances or evil seductresses using sex to cheat and exploit men. Depictions of naked women were often linked to demonic power.

Heresy and the Inquisition

Misogyny is one theory that explains the increasing persecution of women as witches during the late medieval era. Another factor was the Church's war on heresy—beliefs that contradicted Church doctrine. Heretical groups such as the Waldensians and Cathars developed such a following in the 12th century that, in 1233, the Pope set up the Inquisition with wide-ranging powers to investigate, accuse, try, and punish heretics. Over the next few centuries the Inquisition built a fearsome reputation—torture was routinely used to extract confessions, and those accused of heresy who refused to confess were burned at the stake.

Magic was now considered more of a threat to the Church because it appeared to have much in common with heresy. Both were described as the work of the Devil and involved ignorance and excessive pride (for ignoring the Church) as well as trickery and deceit. Heretics began to fall under suspicion for sorcery and witches for heresy.



IN CONTEXT

Women, lust, and witchery

German Inquisitor Heinrich Kramer explicitly linked women and satanic magic in his sensational 1487 best-seller *Malleus Maleficarum*. Kramer believed that all witchcraft came from lust and that women were especially prone to witchery with their sexual appetites, spiritual weakness, and “natural proclivity for evil.” The book was later banned by the Church and Kramer censured.

This historical painting from the 19th century shows a woman accused of witchcraft being brought before Inquisitors.